



Atheistic Existentialism

Introduction

- Existentialism is a philosophical system that traditionally emerged within the 20th century and was traditionally prevalent in both Germany and France.
- Existentialists propose that the existence of the individual subject should be regarded as the foci of philosophical inquiries.

Introduction

- Is a philosophy that exalts individualism
- Main theme: “Existence precedes Essence” ~ Jean Paul Sartre
- *Signifies a denial of predetermined essences in all human beings*
- *Humans are thrown into the world without meaning and fashion their essences through volitions*

Introduction

- Existentialism holds that there is no general essence among individual selves.
- Asserts that one's identity and purpose is fashioned by the individual subject alone.

INTRODUCTION

- TWO KINDS
 1. THEISTIC
 2. ATHEISTIC

PRECURS ORS

Max Striner (1806-1856)

Friedrich Nietzsche (1844-
1900)

Martin Heidegger (1889-1976)

Albert Camus (1913-1960)

Jean Paul Sartre (1905-1980)

A faint, large, purple circular watermark is centered in the upper half of the image. It has a textured, slightly grainy appearance, resembling a stylized flower or a seal.

Max Stirner
(1806 – 1856)

Max Stirner (1806 – 1856)

- Stirnerian philosophy appeared to have predicted the doctrines of Friedrich Nietzsche.
- His philosophy is associated with Egoism

Max Stirner (1806 – 1856)

It is an attitude which promotes the satisfaction of one's personal advantages through the appropriation of life as one's property. – The Egoist

- *“A man who instead of living to an idea – i.e., a spiritual thing- and sacrificing to it his personal advantage serves the latter.” – The Ego and His Own, Striner (1972,27)*

Max Stirner (1806 – 1856)

► EGOIST

- is an individual who gratifies his personal concerns instead of relinquishing them to the demands of an external authority.
- “Appropriation” – activity to possess and assimilate the content of life as one’s own property.

Max Stirner (1806 – 1856)

- ▶ With this, egoist can achieve the highest level of self-affirmation by possessing the wholeness of life as its own property.
- ▶ Demonstrated when egoist employs things, ideas, and beliefs as measures of satisfying and refining one's personal advantages.

Max Stirner (1806 – 1856)

- Affirmation of the mundane world
 - ▶ Stirner surmised that the existence of God, and other spiritual entities are nothing but created illusions of the human imagination.

He writes, *“Pushed to this extremity of disinterested warm-heartedness we must finally become conscious that the spirit, which alone the Christian loves, is nothing; in other words, that the spirit is – a lie.”*

Explanation: The individual self is encouraged to embroider the existence of this worldly life in its entirety.

Max Stirner (1806 – 1856)

- He argues that the self affirmation of the Egoist is depicted in the likeness of a burning candle
 - ▶ *“In using it up, like the candle, which one uses in burning it up. One uses life and, consequently himself the living one, in consuming it and himself. Enjoying life is using life up.”*
 - ▶ The affirmation of the egoist can be optimized when the individual ego experiences and relishes each & every moment of this worldly life to the fullest.
 - ▶ Provides ego with capacity to achieve its highest threshold for self-actualization.

Max Stirner (1806 – 1856)

- Self-actualization of the egoist was declared by Stirner as, *“Nothing is more to me than myself.”*
 - All valuations for egoists are subjective.
- He was against the subjugation of the egoist to the general will or ideals of an established form of authority.
 - Such form of subjugation undermines the uniqueness & creative powers of the egoist.
- ▶ Stirner criticizes the nation state.
 - ▶ He writes
 - ▶ *“The State always has the sole purpose to limit, tame, subordinate the individual – to make him subject himself to some generality or other... Never does a state aim to bring in the free activity of individuals, but always that which is bound to the purpose of the State.”*

Max Stirner (1806 – 1856)

- He also attacked the belief in predestination which is incessantly revered by organized religion.
 - ▶ He cautioned us that predestination entails one's submission to a fixed or unlimited goal. This shall lead to a life of un-freedom, frustration and unhappiness.

Max Stirner (1806 – 1856)

- Ownness or Self Ownership
- Ownness- the ego sustains both its personal rights and subjective powers by asserting authority over his or her own life.
- Liberates him or her from the dictates of any form of authority, whether such assume the traditional laws of society or even one's own natural inclinations.

Max Stirner (1806 – 1856)

- Union of Egoists
 - A voluntary association of unique individuals.
 - Egoists freely unite together to aspire for a common interest or goal.
 - Individuals are also endowed with the decision to depart from the union provided that it no longer satisfies or enhances their personal concerns.
- Stirner concludes Union can ensure egoists to individuate freely & optimize their appropriation of the world for their personal advantages.

Friedrich Nietzsche
(1844-1900)

Friedrich Nietzsche (1844-1900)

- Nietzsche's ideas served as the cornerstone of existential thought
- "God is dead!"
 - ❖ This affirms a complete rejection of metaphysical and religious truths as grounds for reality.
 - ❖ Spiritual dimension is illusory.
 - ❖ To him, the existence of God, afterlife, immortality are nothing but "imaginary causes."
 - ❖ They are nothing but mere projections of one's psychological desire for security & calculability in life.

Friedrich Nietzsche (1844-1900)

- ▶ Expressed in Nietzsche's work , *The Anti-Christ* :
 - He wrote, "*In Christianity neither morality nor religion come into contact with reality at any point...*"
 - Imaginary causes: God, soul, ego, spirit, free will, un-free will
 - Imaginary psychology: Nothing but self-misunderstandings, interpretations of pleasant or unpleasant general feelings for example the condition of the nervus sympathicus, sting of conscience, temptation of the devil, proximity of God

Friedrich Nietzsche (1844-1900)

- ▶ Declaration presupposes a denial of universal morality as the basis for human conduct.
- ▶ Once the existence of God is unveiled as an illusion – God can no longer be implemented as the foundation for human ethical conducts.
 - ▶ This leads to the assertion that all inquiries, dispositions and morals will be founded on the subjective will of individual self.

Friedrich Nietzsche (1844-1900)

- ▶ *“How can the individual achieve its highest level of affirmation in a world without a Divine providence?”*
- In Nietzsche's theory of *“Will to Power,”* which is defined as “The drive to dominate the environment. This drive, so central is the the Will to Power.” It is more than simply the will to survive. It is rather, an inner drive to express vigorous affirmation of all a person's powers.
- ▶ The will to power can be characterized as the inner propensity to dominate and assert superiority over one's life.

Friedrich Nietzsche (1844-1900)

- If one practices a certain code of ethics, the will to power gradually declines ~ the individual weakens.
 - Nietzsche accused Christianity for advocating virtues that undermine & destabilize one's will to life, the will to power.
- Christianity became the dominant religion in human society.
 - Twofold history of good & evil ~ there are two types of moralities practiced by the ancient Greeks:
Master/Aristocratic Morality & Slave Morality

Friedrich Nietzsche (1844-1900)

- Master morality (Built on the will to power)
 - He says, “*What is good? – All that heightens the feeling of power, the will to power, power itself in man. What is bad? – All that proceeds from weakness. What is happiness? – the feeling that power increases; that a resistance is overcome.*”
 - Good is identified with that which is powerful & noble.
 - Evil is linked to weakness & cowardice.

Friedrich Nietzsche (1844-1900)

- Noblemen are egoists.
- Practitioners of master morality are the elite class of society – determine their morals according to their own personal standards; highly individualistic; stand up for their own beliefs regardless of what other people say.

Friedrich Nietzsche (1844-1900)

- Noble individuals
 - Those who have mastery over themselves.
 - Those who thrive on challenges, risks & exposure to forms of novelties in life.
- Slave Morality
 - Practiced by the nonnobles & slaves (lowest class)
 - Slave morality advocates virtues which are beneficial to the existence of sufferers.
 - Virtues: Pity, compassion, honesty, humility, etc.
 - It reveres weakness as a virtue, while nobility & strengths as vices.

Friedrich Nietzsche (1844-1900)

- At first, Master morality > Slave morality.
 - Time progressed & slaves began to resent noblemen
- Slaves upheaved the noble class.
 - Implemented their own morality as virtues
 - Branded the standards of master morality as evil
- Slave morality = basis of Christianity
 - Advocates virtues that promotes forms of powerlessness & self-sacrifice in the individual

Criticisms on the teachings of Christianity:

1. *"Pity stands in antithesis to the tonic emotions which enhance the energy of the feeling of life: it has a depressive effect. One loses force when one pities. – Suffering becomes contagious through pity."*
 2. *He condemned the maxim, "Love thy enemies."*
 3. *"I consider life itself the instinct for growth, for continuance, for accumulation of forces for power: where the will to power is lacking there is decline."*
- The expression of will to power is the most viable way to survive & persevere in life.

Friedrich Nietzsche (1844-1900)

- Consciousness of the “Over man” or “Superman”
 - Achieved once the individual frees self from slave morality and values of master morality are repossessed.
 - Temperament of Over man / Superman = Revitalized faith in creative powers & earthly existence.
 - Superman = Extracts his enjoyment of life by living dangerously.
- Doctrine of *Amor fati* or “love of one’s fate”
 - Most vital element in the Superman

Martin Heidegger (1889-1976)

METAPHYSICAL QUESTION:
WHAT IS BEING?

Martin Heidegger (1889-1976)

- What is Being?
 - the totality of existence.
 - Consists of certain complexities for the reason that the nature of Being is regarded as ambiguous and thus, transcends all forms of schematization.

Martin Heidegger (1889-1976)

- Dasein "There being"
 - one who adopts an authentic mode of being.
 - procurement of self-realization through the existential question "Who am I?"
 - possesses the drive to surmount the boundaries of tradition and go beyond the level of mediocrity.
- Being in the world.
 - human beings are depicted as constituent of the world and is subject to all conditions of the physical nature and the social world of human beings.

Martin Heidegger (1889-1976)

- Dasein is one who engages in Care or Concern (Sorge)
 - the human subject recognizes self-realization and emancipation can only be obtained through communion with other selves.
 - Dasein loses authenticity through an adherence to the conditions of the human sphere.
 - Dasein regress to an inauthentic form of existence, the das man.

Martin Heidegger

(1889-1976)

- The das man is one who repudiates forms of superiority and aspires for typical and ordinary way of life.
 - Das man's mode of existence demands that human beings should align their personal needs, dispositions and ideals according to the standards of the common good.
 - The mindset of the das man not only leads to a monotonous way of life
 - the dissolution of individual will and uniqueness
 - individual freedom and authenticity can be sustained through the disposition of Dasein.

Martin Heidegger (1889-1976)

- Dasein is referred to as a "project towards the future"
 - The human subject is one who continuously aspires for possibilities in the future.
 - Dasein is a self which is fluid, dynamic and in process.
 - However, Dasein inevitably becomes aware of an ultimate possibility.
 - The phenomenon of death
 - Dasein is a being towards death

Martin Heidegger (1889-1976)

- DEATH

- extinction of one's possibilities for self actualization.
- is something which the individual must face alone
- is inevitable and happens by chance
- obliterates Dasein's attribute of "Being in the world"

Martin Heidegger

(1889-1976)

- ANXIETY

- The individual self starts to flee
- Dasein relinquishes authenticity
- Adopts the das man mode of existence
- The human subject escape from the anxiety of death
- This is shown through a complete denial of death as a necessary element of the human condition

Martin Heidegger (1889-1976)

- The Das Man approach to the phenomenon of death shall only result to forms of weakness and decadence.
- One's reclamation of authenticity is secured through the affirmation of death as an inescapable fact of human living
- the individual self reclaims the mode of Dasein and achieves liberation from anxiety of death.
- the self obtains self-empowerment over life itself.

Albert Camus

(1913-1960)

EXISTENTIAL ISSUE OF ABSURDITY

Albert Camus (1913-60)

- Existential Issue of Absurdity
 - life is meaningless
 - Shows how an individual can approach and confront the nothingness of the human reality

Albert Camus (1913-1960)

- Absurdity of Life
 - Founded on his negation of God as the basic foundation of human existence
 - Human beings are void of any pre-ordained essences
 - Existence of the human subject is purposeless, superfluous and thus, meaningless
 - All morals and standpoints are determined by the subjective will of the individual

Albert Camus (1913-1960)

- Individual self as the sole legitimate authority of standards and valuations
- Stems from the awareness that life becomes unveiled as a “mechanical routine”
- The issue of alienation is indeed an integral part of Camus’ idea of absurdity.

Albert Camus (1913-1960)

- Awareness of the Absurdity
 - Estrangement of individual shall be considered a perpetual fact of the absurd world
 - “Is life worth living at all?”
 - Suicide – complete surrender to the voidness of human existence
 - “Philosophical suicide” – attempt to explain reality according to metaphysical assumptions and universal truths
 - Such an attempt is deemed as a deviation from absurd realities

Albert Camus (1913-1960)

- He was against traditional philosophies which advocate universal truths as appropriate ways to acquisition of knowledge
- “All thought is anthropomorphic” and has no meaning.

Albert Camus (1913-1960)

- The truth is dependent on the the viewpoint of the individual subject
- The notion of truth is unveiled as relative conception instead of a universal fact of human life
- The use of religion is an appropriate way of dealing with the absurd.
- Religion is nothing but an amalgamation of imaginary causes
- Resignation to religion ushers in forms of self-denial and resentment towards the actual world

Albert Camus (1913-1960)

- Living life without hope or meaning
 - actualized through the confrontation of the absurd as necessary elements of concrete human life.
 - Self achieves authenticity and prevails over the absurd world.



Jean Paul Sartre (1905-1980)

SARTREAN PHILOSOPHY

Jean Paul Sartre (1905-1980)

- Sartrean philosophy- the main paradigm in existential thought
- *Being and Nothingness*
- 2 regions of being:
 - a. being- in- itself (en soi)- devoid of consciousness and subject to the causal laws of nature
 - b. Being- for- itself (pour soi)- possesses consciousness and freedom

Jean Paul Sartre (1905-1980)

- Claims that human beings are aware of objects and are capable of injecting nothingness into the world
- He declared that human beings are affirmed as free and self-determining
- Man exists, turns up, appears on the scene, and only afterwards, defines himself.

Jean Paul Sartre (1905-1980)

- He also renounced all types of determinism
- theory of Facticity versus Transcendence
- “man is condemned to be free”
- Sartre stated that in certain situations, one’s decision can influence the choice of others
- According to him, responsibility is affiliated with the feeling of anxiety.

Jean Paul Sartre (1905-1980)

- Bad Faith
- promotes forms of weakness and cowardice
- Sartre's view of social relationships was presented in his play, *No Exit*
- "Hell is the Other!"

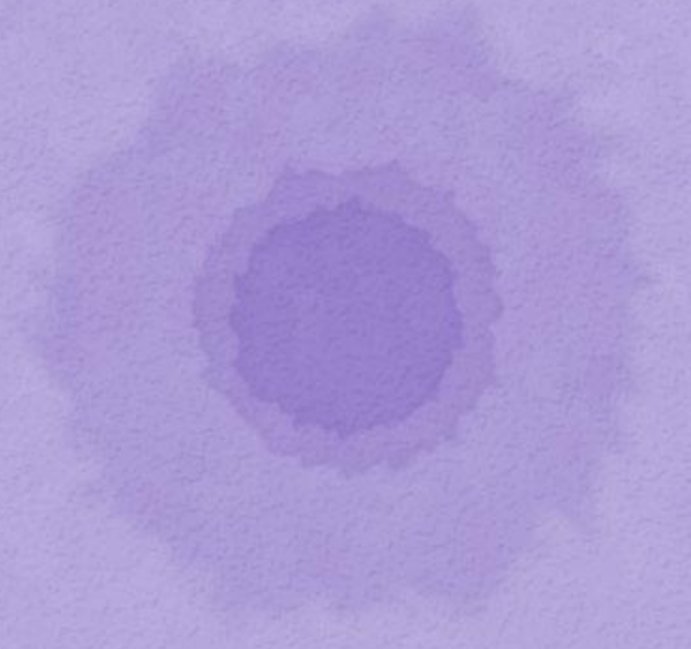
Jean Paul Sartre (1905-1980)

➤ Sartre's theory of "Being for Others"

He shared the views of Martin Heidegger and Martin Buber, who argue alongside with him that the existence of the self is dependent on its relationship with the Other

Jean Paul Sartre (1905-1980)

- two consequences when the self becomes objectified by the perception of the Other
 - a. the look of the other threatens one's freedom
 - b. the enslavement of the self by the Other leads to conflict



Conclusión

Conclusion

- Atheistic existentialists are not in favor of advocating forms of lawlessness and arbitrary behavior as viable modes of human conduct.
 - An authentic lifestyle entails affirmation of individual responsibility
 - Humans must become highly reflective of the possible outcomes of their desired course of action

Conclusion

- Encourage us to become resolute in our own subjective convictions and potentials regardless of what traditional society dictates
- Keep in mind that they are not in favor of nullifying the approaches of human tradition
- The highest level of self affirmation can be produced by transcending the overriding social tensions in contemporary society